his father, by conquest alone.[2]

This was a silly assertion to make of a child, but the Earl of Moray knew that the Scots had a tradition of following the strongest man, not the next in line by blood. Sure enough, David's rule was soon challenged by Edward Balliol, son of the deposed John (who had died in France some fifteen years earlier, having been released from the Tower of London on condition that he never return to Scotland). With a small mercenary army and the support of a handful of English barons who had lost their Scottish territories and wanted them back, Edward Balliol took ship and landed his men near Kinghorn, on the eastern coast, in August 1332.

On his way to repel the invasion, the Earl of Moray was taken suddenly and violently ill and died. The Scottish nobles elected another of their number, the Earl of Mar, to replace him. With the help of David's illegitimate half brother Robert and the son of the dead Earl of Moray, the new regent led thirty thousand Scots against the little English army, and was thoroughly and embarrassingly beaten. "The Scots were defeated chiefly by the English archers," says the *Chronicle of Lanercost*, "who so blinded and wounded the faces of the first division of the Scots by an incessant discharge of arrows, that they could not support each other." More than half of the Scottish army was killed or taken prisoner in this defeat, known as the Battle of Dupplin Moor. The Earl of Mar died fighting, after only nine days as regent. Robert fell too; so did the young Earl of Moray.[3]

Edward Balliol marched triumphantly to Scone and had himself crowned king of Scotland on October 4. But he had no supporters in Scotland; three months after his coronation, he was forced to flee Scotland by a reassembled Scottish army loyal to David.

At this point, both kings of Scotland appealed to Edward III for help. David's ambassadors arrived at York, where the king was holding court, and begged him to assist the young king "as an ally ought to do, seeing that he had his sister to wife." Balliol's officers appeared at the same time, pointing out that Balliol and his allies were merely taking back land that had once been theirs.

Nationality, and the chance to get Scotland back, won out over family ties; Edward decided to support Balliol. "The King's council was of the opinion," writes Thomas Gray, "that he was not bound so to act against his own subjects." An English army joined Balliol and his men, and in early July of 1333, the combined armies of Balliol and Edward III attacked the border town of Berwick. This time, the Scottish defenses were outmanned, and "a great number of barons, knights, and common people were slain." Berwick surrendered, and Balliol marched to Scone for the second time.[4]